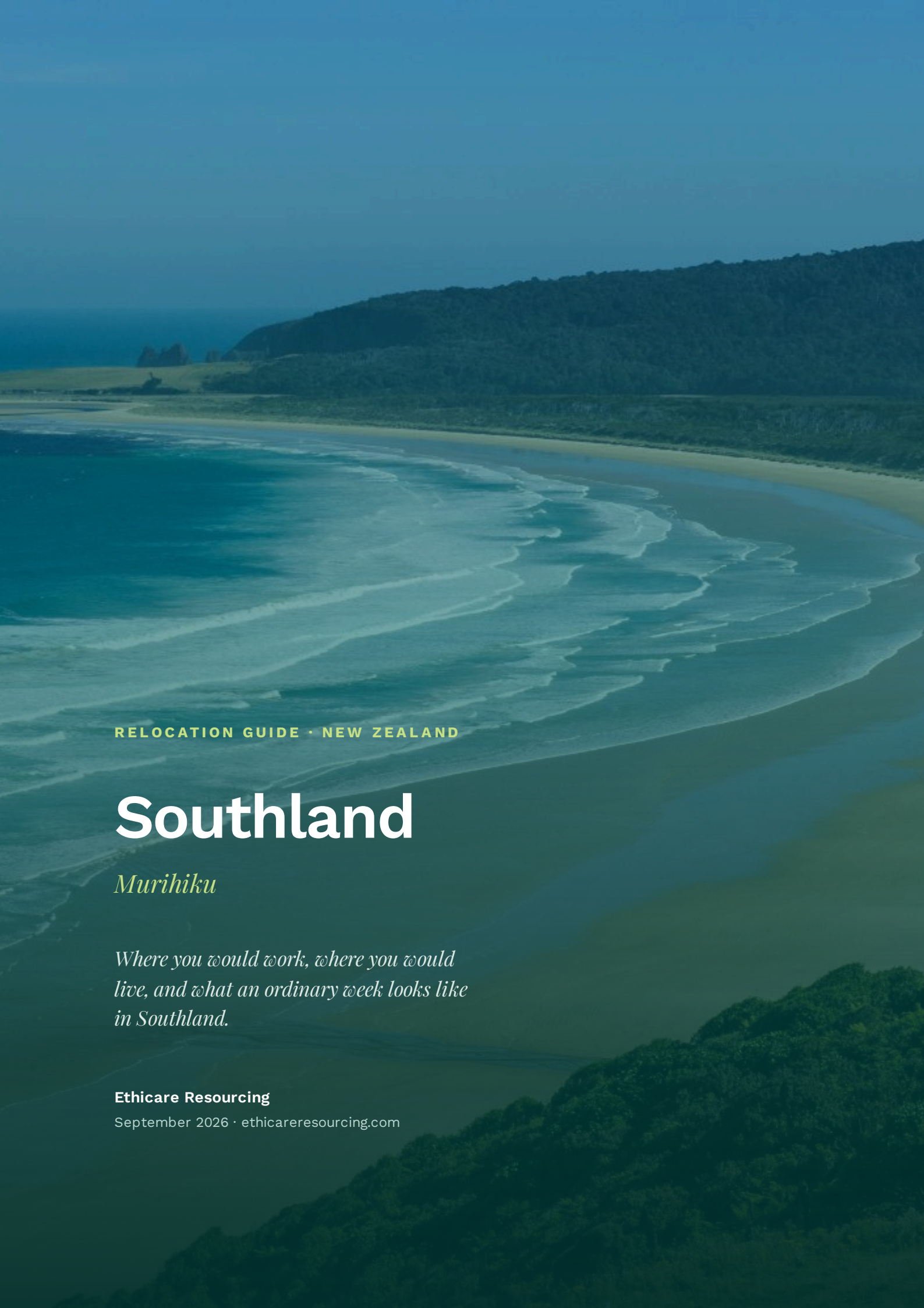




RELOCATION GUIDE • NEW ZEALAND

Southland

Murihiku

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Southland.

Ethicare Resourcing

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Nau mai ki Murihiku

Welcome to Southland

Moving country is a bold thing to do, and it is rarely only about the job. This guide is here to make the practical parts easier: where people live, what the work is like, how you would get around, and what an ordinary week might actually feel like.

It is written by people who arrange these moves for a living, which means two things. We know the questions that arrive at two in the morning. And we would rather tell you the awkward parts now than have you find them in month three.

Nothing in here is a pitch. If Southland turns out to be the wrong answer for you, this guide should help you work that out just as quickly – and that is a good outcome, not a failed one.

Whatever you decide, you are welcome to ask us anything at all.

Sophie

FOUNDER, ETHICARE RESOURCING

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This is the short version. Every section here has a fuller chapter on our website, kept up to date — so if something looks time-sensitive, check there. We have left rents, salaries and other figures out on purpose: a number that was right when this was written would be quietly wrong by the time you read it, and a PDF cannot be corrected once it is sent. Those live on the site instead.



01

MURIHIKU

Welcome to Southland

Nau mai, haere mai ki Murihiku.

~103,000

People across the whole region, in an area larger than Wales.

~57,000

In Invercargill, the southernmost city in New Zealand and one of the southernmost in the world.

1 BASE HOSPITAL

In Invercargill, serving Southland, Fiordland and Rakiura, run by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora, with rural services across the region.

The last place people look, and one of the best

Southland is the southernmost region in New Zealand, and it is bigger and more varied than most people realise. Invercargill sits near the south coast with around fifty-seven thousand people and the region's base hospital. Gore is an hour north-east through farming country. Te Anau is two hours north-west, on the edge of Fiordland National Park. And Rakiura — Stewart Island — lies an hour by ferry beyond Bluff, almost entirely national park.

The clinical picture here is strong, and this is the part that surprises people. Southland has a base hospital serving the whole region, with a rural network reaching into Fiordland and the western districts. It is real hospital medicine, in a city where a family home costs less than anywhere else in the country.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Southland specifically. Anything true of New Zealand generally — visas, registration, tax, renting law, driving licences, schools — lives once in [Moving to New Zealand](#) rather than being repeated here.

If you read nothing else, read [Why Southland](#) for the full case — and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Cost of living](#), because the numbers here are unlike anywhere else in the country.



02

THE CASE FOR SOUTHLAND

Why Southland

Southland gets fewer enquiries than any region in this collection and produces more contented clinicians than most. The gap between those two facts is what this chapter is about.

MONDAY TO FRIDAY

Ten minutes to work, and free parking. Invercargill's streets were laid out with an optimism about traffic that never materialised, which is entirely to your benefit.

AFTER WORK, SUMMER

Light until nearly ten. A beach at Oreti, a round of golf, a bike ride, or the estuary. The long evenings are the region's secret pleasure.

AFTER WORK, WINTER

Dark early and often wet. This is when the indoor life matters — and Invercargill has an unusually good stock of pools, gyms, a velodrome and community sport for its size.

The arithmetic

Clinical pay in New Zealand is set nationally. You earn the same in Invercargill as in Auckland or Queenstown. What changes is what it costs to live — and here it costs less than anywhere else in the country.

That is not a small difference. Invercargill has the lowest house prices of any New Zealand city, by a clear margin. A large four-bedroom family home on a proper section, ten minutes from the hospital, costs less than a modest apartment in Queenstown two hours north. On a single clinical salary you can buy here almost immediately, and on two you can do it comfortably and still travel.

The six things people ask us

Yes — and this is the point people miss. Southland has a base hospital covering a whole region, which means acute medicine and surgery, an emergency department, maternity, paediatrics, imaging, intensive care and a broad outpatient service. It is proper hospital medicine with a wide catchment, not a rural outpost. [Healthcare here](#) sets out what is and is not done in the region.

It is the coolest and one of the wettest regions in New Zealand, and we would rather say so plainly. Summers are mild rather than hot, winters are cool and damp rather than severe, and the wind is constant. What people find is that the long summer light and the green landscape compensate more than they expected — and that the clothing solves most of it.

Who we'd steer further north

Southland gets fewer enquiries than any region we cover and produces more contented clinicians than most – the maths works, the hospital is steady, and Fiordland does the rest. Bring proper clothing and low expectations of the weather; everything else over-delivers.



03

THE BOTTOM OF THE COUNTRY

Southland at a glance

Southland is a broad, intensely green plain, bounded by mountains to the north-west and a wild ocean to the south. Nothing about it is dramatic until you reach the edges — and then it is as dramatic as anywhere on earth.

ACROSS INVERCARGILL

10 minutes, at any hour
of any day.

→ BLUFF

30 minutes south, for
the oysters, the ferry
and Stirling Point.

→ RIVERTON & ORETI BEACH

15 to 40 minutes west
along the coast.

The shape of the region

The middle of Southland is farmland: the Southland Plains, some of the most productive pasture in the country, running from the Takitimu Mountains down to the sea. Invercargill sits near the southern edge on the Waihōpai River, with the Oreti and New River estuaries beside it and Oreti Beach's long grey sweep to the west.

North-east through the plains is Gore, an hour away, on the Mataura River — a farming and brown-trout town, and the region's second centre. North-west, past Winton and Lumsden, the land climbs into the Te Anau basin and then into **Fiordland**: 1.2 million hectares of World Heritage wilderness, glacial sounds, and some of the highest rainfall on the planet.

The four seasons

Indicative daytime highs. Snow at sea level is uncommon; frost is normal. Inland around Gore and Te Anau the range is wider at both ends.

The light is the thing nobody warns you about. At 46 degrees south the summer days are enormous — light from before five in the morning until nearly ten at night around the solstice. It reshapes how you live for four months of the year. The corollary is a genuinely dark midwinter, and it is fair to weigh both.

Healthcare in Southland

This is the chapter that separates Southland from the other far-south options. Unlike Central Otago, this region has a base hospital — and that single fact changes what a career here can look like.

REAL HOSPITAL BREADTH

A base hospital in a region with no competing centre means you see everything the region produces. Scope is wide and referral options are further away, so you make more of the decisions.

RURAL AND REMOTE REACH

Fiordland, Rakiura and the western districts. Genuinely remote medicine, search-and-rescue interaction, and a tourism injury load from the Great Walks and the sounds.

A STRONG AGRICULTURAL CASELOAD

Farming is the region's economy, and farm injury, occupational health and rural mental health are a real and distinctive part of the work.

The shape of the service

Public hospital and specialist services are delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora. The base hospital in Invercargill serves the whole region — roughly a hundred thousand people spread over an area larger than Wales — carrying acute medicine and surgery, an emergency department, intensive care, maternity, paediatrics, imaging, and a full outpatient and day-procedure service.

Beyond the city, care runs through a rural network: community and district services across the plains, and rural facilities in the northern and western districts serving Gore, the Te Anau basin, Fiordland and Rakiura. Distance is a live clinical factor. Retrieval and transfer — by road, and by air from Te Anau and the island — are a normal part of the working year.

Working with te ao Māori

This is the rohe of Ngāi Tahu, and Murihiku has a long history of settlement, harvest and trade along the southern coast and the islands. Iwi-led health providers are an established part of care delivery, and the region's health equity picture — rural, dispersed, with real access barriers and a significant Māori and Pacific population in the city — is central to the work rather than adjacent to it.

Practically: karakia at the start of meetings, te reo used on the ward, whānau involved in decisions. You are not expected to arrive fluent — you are expected to try. The national chapter [Te ao Māori at work](#) covers pronunciation, the words you will hear and marae etiquette.

Before you can start

Registration with your professional body, and the visa that goes with it, are national processes and identical wherever in New Zealand you land. They are explained once, properly, in [Eligibility & registration](#) and [Immigration & visas](#).

How the health system is funded and structured — ACC (accident cover for everyone, no fault attached), primary care, what things cost, how it differs from the NHS or a private system — lives in [How the health system works](#).

Where clinicians live

Invercargill is a city of wide streets and generous sections where every suburb is ten minutes from the hospital.

That removes the usual trade-off entirely, so this chapter is about character and about how far out of the city you want to be.

WAIKIWI & GRASMERE

Established northern suburbs, well regarded and well served by schools. A common landing spot for relocating clinical families, and close to the hospital.

WINDSOR & GEORGETOWN

Solid, central, family housing on the eastern side. Good value even by local standards, and walkable to schools and shops.

AVENAL & GLADSTONE

Older character housing near Queens Park, the city's large and lovely botanic park. Villas and bungalows, mature trees.

Fiordland

How renting works — the application pack, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards — is national and covered once in [Renting in New Zealand](#).

Cost of living

Invercargill has the lowest house prices of any city in New Zealand, and it is not a narrow lead. On a clinical salary that is not a small convenience — it changes what your money is for.

WAIKIWI, GRASMERE & WINDSOR

The city's more sought-after family suburbs, and still modest by national standards. Where most relocating clinical families start.

AVENAL & GLADSTONE

Character housing near Queens Park. Lovely streets, older homes — check the insulation carefully.

ROSEDALE & NEWFIELD

The best value in an already cheap city. Straightforward family housing at prices that surprise everyone arriving from overseas.

Why there are no prices on this page

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Southland against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

What the numbers actually mean

Put concretely: a large four-bedroom family home on a proper section, ten minutes from the hospital, in a well-regarded school zone, costs a fraction of a modest apartment in Queenstown two hours north. Most clinicians we place in Southland buy within their first year or two, rather than renting for a decade while they save.

What that buys beyond the house is the interesting part. Clinicians here tend to travel more, work fewer extra shifts, and reach financial decisions years earlier than colleagues on identical pay elsewhere. That is the real proposition, and the weather is the price of it.

Renting, by area

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent is forty-five per cent of it — the smallest share of any region in this collection.

Two lines run higher than the national pattern and both are honest: winter power, and a car you will genuinely need. They still do not come close to closing the gap the rent line opens.



07

EMPTY ROADS, LONG DISTANCES

Getting around

Getting around inside Southland is the easiest of any region in this collection. Getting out of it is the hardest. Both are worth understanding before you commit.

THE PLAINS

Straight, quiet, well-sealed roads through farmland. Winton half an hour, Gore an hour, and almost no traffic on any of it.

THE COAST ROAD

West to Riverton and the Catlins east — the Southern Scenic Route. Slower, winding and worth taking for its own sake.

THE FIORDLAND ROAD

Two hours north-west to Te Anau, then the Milford road beyond it — one of the great drives anywhere, and subject to avalanche closures in winter.

The commute

Ten minutes across Invercargill, at any hour. The city was laid out on a generous grid with wide streets, and the traffic never arrived to fill them. Parking is free and abundant, including at the hospital. There is no rush hour to speak of.

If you are arriving from a large city, this is the change you will feel every single day. Clinicians tell us the reclaimed time is the thing they would least want to give back.

The ferry to Rakiura

From Bluff, thirty minutes south of the city, a passenger ferry crosses Foveaux Strait to Oban on Stewart Island in about an hour. There are also light aircraft from Invercargill Airport, which take twenty minutes and are often the better option in poor weather.

Worth knowing: Foveaux Strait has a reputation, and it earns it. The crossing can be genuinely rough. If you plan to work or travel to the island regularly, the flight is what most people end up doing.

Distances worth knowing

Times on dry roads. Add for frost and fog in winter, and always check the Milford road before setting out.

Converting your licence, buying a car, and what a warrant of fitness and registration involve are national matters, explained once in [Driving & licences](#).



08

OYSTERS, BLUE COD AND CHEESE ROLLS

Food, shopping & the everyday

Southland has a stronger food identity than any region in this collection, and almost none of it is fashionable. It comes from the sea, the farms and a hundred and fifty years of Scottish stubbornness, and locals are unembarrassed about all of it.

INVERCARGILL

A modest but improving scene — good cafés, a handful of strong restaurants, craft beer, and the best-value eating out in the country. The city centre has been steadily redeveloped.

RIVERTON & BLUFF

Small coastal spots punching above their weight, particularly for seafood. Where locals take visitors.

TE ANAU

Tourism-facing and better than you'd expect for the size, with prices to match the visitor market.

What comes out of the water

Bluff oysters are the region's great annual event. Wild dredge oysters from Foveaux Strait, in season roughly March to August, and by common agreement among the best in the world. There is a festival, there are queues, and there is a genuine local calendar built around the opening.

Blue cod is the local fish and the correct order at any chippy in the region. **Crayfish**, pāua and mussels come off the same coast, and **tītī** — muttonbird — remains a customary harvest on the islands off Rakiura, sold locally in season and an acquired taste that Southlanders are pleased to watch you acquire.

What comes off the land

Southland is intensively farmed dairy and sheep country, and the produce reflects it. Local lamb and beef, exceptional dairy, and a real culture of home baking and preserving that has survived here better than in the cities. Gore is brown-trout capital and takes that seriously too.

The farmers' markets in Invercargill and Gore cover produce, meat and baking. Between them and the coast you can eat extremely well from within fifty kilometres, and cheaply.

Eating out and the everyday

Specialist and imported ingredients are the honest weak point. There are Asian and Indian grocers in Invercargill and the range is better than the city's size suggests, but it is narrower than any of the main centres. If a particular cuisine is central to how your family eats, check before you commit — the national chapter [Finding your feet & your people](#) covers where to look and which communities are established here.



09

WHY YOU WOULD PUT UP WITH THE WEATHER

Fiordland, Rakiura & the south coast

This is the answer to every reservation in this guide. Two hours from your front door is one of the great wildernesses on earth. An hour by sea is an island that is almost entirely national park. And the coast between them is emptier than anywhere else you will live.

MILFORD SOUND

About four hours from the city on one of the great drives anywhere. Go on a wet day — that is when the waterfalls are extraordinary and the buses are fewer.

DOUBTFUL SOUND

Larger, quieter and harder to reach, via Lake Manapouri. Overnight trips are worth doing once and then again.

THE MILFORD TRACK

Booked out a year ahead by people flying from the other side of the world. You would be two hours from the start.

Fiordland

1.2 million hectares of World Heritage wilderness, beginning about two hours north-west of the city. Glacier-carved sounds, rainforest, waterfalls and some of the highest rainfall on the planet. Most New Zealanders visit once. You would live at the edge of it.

Rakiura / Stewart Island

An hour by ferry from Bluff, or twenty minutes by light aircraft. Four hundred people, eighty-five per cent national park, and one of the best places in the world to see kiwi in the wild — genuinely, walking on a beach at dusk. There is the Rakiura Track for three days, day walks from Oban, Ulva Island's bird sanctuary, and a night sky with almost no light pollution in it.

Southlanders treat it as a long weekend rather than an expedition. That is a remarkable thing to be able to say about a place like this.

Useful links

The region's official visitor site: the coast, the towns, events and the scenic route.

FIORDLAND

[Fiordland & Te Anau](#) ↗

Te Anau, Manapouri, Milford and Doubtful Sound — what to do and when to go.

OUTDOORS

[Department of Conservation](#) ↗

Great Walks, huts, bookings and alerts for Fiordland and Rakiura.

COUNCIL

Invercargill City Council [↗](#)

Local services, pools, libraries, parks and community programmes.

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Southland. Everything national – visas, registration, tax, renting, driving, schools, te ao Māori – lives in [Moving to New Zealand](#). This is the region people overlook and then quietly recommend to everyone. When you'd like to talk it through, [we're here](#), with no pressure and no pipeline.

Where to go next

You do not need a moving date, a decision or a CV to talk to us. If Southland is on your list, tell us what you do and what you are weighing up, and we will be straight with you about whether we can help.

Everything on our website is free to read whether or not you ever work with us.

The full Southland guide – ethicareresourcing.com/destinations/southland-new-zealand

Registration pathway checker – ethicareresourcing.com/pathway-checker

What reaches your bank account – ethicareresourcing.com/take-home-pay

What the move itself costs – ethicareresourcing.com/cost-calculator

Talk to us – hello@ethicareresourcing.com
